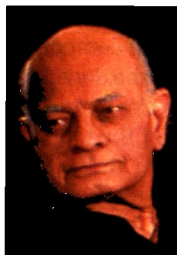


Brajesh Mishra

No to Subservient Relations

While most Indians want better ties with the US they will not tolerate a submissive foreign policy



Except for the Left parties and some fringe elements, most Indians want better relations with the US, abiding friendship and deeper and wider cooperation between the two countries. But even amongst those who want such relations, there are vital differences. There are some who want to get close to the US at any cost, give any concession, surrender

on each and every point. They wholeheartedly support the Indo-US nuclear deal. Among them are corporate houses, big businessmen, people with close family ties, kins and friends in the large community of people of Indian origin living in the US. Let us not forget others who are fervently anti-Chinese, wary of Chinese economic growth and desirous of US support for India to take on China, give them a knock-out blow and overcome the humiliation caused by the Chinese aggression in 1962.

The vast majority of the urban middle class stands firmly for Indo-US friendship as between two sovereign equals. Obviously it is not that India is the equal of the US in every way. That is not possible. (For the last six decades, Pakistan has tried unsuccessfully and with disastrous consequences to be the equal of India in every respect.) Nevertheless, this majority will not tolerate a subservient relationship. The US administration is prone to asking for support for its international goals. The US has a global political and economic agenda. India is much more focused on South Asia, West Asia and South-East Asia (we are just beginning to take strategic interest in Central Asia and the Far East).

Even today there are sharp differences in the approach of the two countries towards Iran and Pakistan. For various reasons the US wants a regime change in Iran even if it leads to resorting to armed force. India, on the other hand, is keen to maintain its traditional relations with Iran and to pursue greater economic interaction, especially in the oil and gas sectors. Further, given the present day relations with Pakistan, India needs Iran's cooperation to provide it access to Afghanistan and Central Asia. Then there are our interests in the Persian Gulf where Iran's importance has increased manifold since the US invasion of Iraq and the removal and hanging of Saddam Hussein. Can we afford an Iran unfriendly to us? Another contradiction

relates to Pakistan. For years we have criticised, and rightly so, China's assistance in the nuclear and military fields to Pakistan. But what about the US? Let us ignore the Cold War period. Compared to the huge military supplies, apart from financial aid to Pakistan from the US between September 2001 and the present day, Chinese assistance pales into insignificance. A substantial portion of the aid is meant for use against India. Would this contradiction disappear if we were to become a close ally of the US? Unlikely.

In the coming years, the success or failure of India's foreign and national security policies will depend crucially on



NEW DEAL: Prime Minister Manmohan Singh (right) and US President George W. Bush in New Delhi

the management of its relations with four countries—the US, Russia, Japan and China. While it is necessary to develop close relations with the US and Japan, it is equally important to nurture the friendship with Russia and to settle the border problem with China. This last cannot be achieved in a state of hostile or adversarial relations with China. There are tensions in Indo-American, as also in Russian-American relations, which will create problems for India in its pursuit of good or workable relations with the four countries.

The management of the contradictions requires firmness and making the right choices at all times. Two examples will illustrate the point. In the case of Iran, when the matter of its nuclear programme came up in the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) in September